

turned into the word for “war” (“Krieg”), in order to explain *-k’i* in *siu-k’i* as dative case *-kä*, which would be feasible in the light of Baxter-Starostin **ke*, but not Ramstedt *k’i*. However, Old Turkic *sü* means “army”, and not “war”, and the replacement is not justified. In addition, Xiong-nu **s(l)u(s)-ke* has a [+back] vowel, while Old Turkic word *sü* “army” has a front vowel. Furthermore, if **-ke* were a dative or directional case, it would almost certain be indicated in the Chinese translation by prepositions 於 or 于 “in”, “to”. However, the absence of these prepositions clearly indicates that “army” is to be treated as a subject if we are dealing with SVO language, or as subject or direct object, if Xiong-nu was SOV language. Finally, Chinese 出 “go out”, “to put out” is translated as “ausziehen” rather than “ausgehen” or “hinausführen.” Ramstedt does not stop here at his more than free interpretation of both Chinese translation and phonology. His *t’i-li-kang* further becomes *tai-li-kang*, and then magically turns into *tal’iqyŋ* or *tal’iqayŋ*. The latter then is compared with Old Turkic *tašyqyŋ* “ziehet aus.” Needless to say, such ad hoc interpretation of both Chinese phonology and translation does not give too much credibility to Ramstedt’s “reading”. Furthermore, the title **bok-kok* is compared with Old Turkic *bögü* “der wise” and Written Mongolian *böge* “schamann,” ignoring completely the [+back] vocalism of the word in Xiong-nu and the final *-k* in it, absent in both Turkic and Mongolian. The last word, **Ko-thok-tang* “to capture” is left without any Turkic interpretation at all.

Bazin’s explanation, also utilizing Turkic, does not fare much better. Bazin, however, must be given its due that his philological approach to the text is more solid than that of Ramstedt: he at least cites the poem in the original Chinese transcription and uses Karlgren’s Chinese reconstruction (Kargren 1940) to interpret it (Bazin 1948: 208–209). However, even Bazin does not completely escape the temptation of a free interpretation of the poem that goes: “Si l’armée sort, Liu Yao sera capturé.” There is no conditional in the poem above. This is however, insignificant, compared to the major blunder that comes next. Citing Eberhard’s authority, Bazin hypothesizes that Chinese usually divided words incorrectly in foreign languages (1948: 209–210). There is however, no reference to Eberhard’s saying this anywhere in print, and one can assume that Bazin might misunderstood personal communi-